

The Glorious King of Tantras of the Great Commitment

Śrī Mahāsamaya Tantra Rāja Nāma · Toh 390 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་དམ་ཚག་ཆེ་པའི་རིན་པོ་ལྷ་ཀུན་གྱི་ཐུག་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱ

Toh 390 in the Kangyur is a tantric scripture known in English as The Glorious King of Tantras of the Great Commitment, corresponding to the Sanskrit Śrī Mahāsamaya Tantra Rāja and the Tibetan Dpal dam pa chen po'i rgyud kyi rgyal po. It belongs to the class of Buddhist tantric texts and concerns the samaya, or sacred commitments and vows, that practitioners undertake within the tantric path, presented through the voice of the bodhisattva Vajragarbha addressing an assembly of yoginīs. The text opens in the characteristic manner of a buddha-word scripture, with the Blessed One abiding in meditative absorption within a tantric setting, framing the ensuing teachings on commitment and conduct as a direct revelation. Translated into Tibetan by the Indian abbot Ratnavajra together with the translator-monk Śākya Yeshe and later revised against a subsequent manuscript, it is preserved among the tantric scriptures of the Kangyur.

Translated by the Indian abbot Ratnavajra and the translator-monk Śākya Yeshe, edited and finalized. Subsequently it was revised by collation with a later manuscript copy.

In the Indian language: Śrī Mahāsamaya Tantra Rāja Nāma. In the Tibetan language: The Glorious King of Tantras of the Great Commitment, thus named. Homage to Mañjuśrī in his youthful form.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, was abiding in meditative absorption within the bhaga of the noble vajra-queen, the embodiment of the body, speech, and mind of all tathāgatas.

Then, from within the innumerable yoginīs, the great bodhisattva Vajragarbha smiled upon the bodhisattva Vajragarbha and proclaimed the stages of the commitments (samaya):

If one does not possess the commitments,
even though one strives, accomplishment will not be obtained —
like a fruit without a cause.
At life's end one goes to hell.

Therefore guard the commitments with great care.
Since they are received from one's teacher, the buddha,
the fifty aspects that constitute one's own extraordinary teacher
are to be preserved.

The eight common ones and the fourteen —
these are to be definitely known.
Those are the general commitments;
the specific commitments are also to be guarded.

The five aggregates are the five buddha families.
The five elements are the five mother-consorts.
The sense sources, the male bodhisattvas and the female bodhisattvas —

The aggregate of form belongs to Vairocana:
abandoning forgetfulness, contempt, and the like toward him,
one is to make offerings and praises and so forth.
In ultimate truth it is self-knowing awareness;
I have spoken of it in order to accumulate the accumulations.

Feeling and the rest are likewise.

The earth is the eye of the buddhas;
in the three modes of conduct do not be distracted.
Wherever it is said, guard it accordingly.

Water and the rest are likewise.
The eyes and the rest are likewise.
Form and the rest: guard them likewise.

The yogin who has entered the maṇḍala
is to be venerated as a vajra-holder.
Contempt, abuse, and the like are to be abandoned.
For all male and female sentient beings,
guard the commitment of heroes and heroines.

With regard to food and the like, and in due season,
guard the commitment through the practice of nectar-mixture.
With respect to the five meats and the five nectars —
in one's own practice and in the practice of others —
rejoicing accordingly is the commitment.

In brief, with respect to the substances of the manifest world and of existence:
to guard the commitments and to make offerings —

the restraint of faults of body is the kāya,
the restraint of faults of speech is declared to be the vāk,
the restraint of faults of mind is declared to be the citta.

Through the white rays of light of OM,
the desire realm is purified:
this is the guarding of the body commitment.
Toward it make offerings, praises, and so forth.
Know that in its condensed form it is OM.

AḤ, with its red color,
is the speech commitment of the purified form realm.
HŪM, with its black color,
is the commitment of the purified formless realm.

OM dwells truly at the crown of the head.
AḤ likewise dwells at the throat.
HŪM radiates and reabsorbs at the heart.

The twelve ḍākinīs of body
are the commitment of the purification of the desire realm.
The twelve ḍākinīs of speech
are the commitment of the purification of the form realm.
The twelve ḍākinīs of mind
are the commitment of the purification of the formless realm.
All are condensed into OM, AḤ, and HŪM.

OM: the twelve bodies of cause.
AḤ: the twelve bodies of the path.
HŪM: the twelve bodies of the result.

The body, speech, and mind of great bliss —
their commitment is the union of gnosis as one.
The glorious body, speech, and mind of the dharmakāya —
their commitment is the union of gnosis as one.
The body, speech, and mind of the saṃbhogakāya —
their commitment is gnosis becoming one.
The body, speech, and mind of the emanation body —
their commitment is the union of gnosis as one.

Within the syllable HŪṂ itself, the very essence of great bliss,
body, speech, and mind, and also
gnosis and the four aspects —
OM, AḤ, HŪṂ, and furthermore . . .

Proclaimed by the Sage in four branches for each —
in cause, path, and result,
forty-eight in all are to be known.

AM and HĀṂ, the two:
know them as the essential nature of the mantra.
The mantra count is twenty-one thousand
six hundred recitations — this too is to be known.

The movement of the hands is dance by its very nature;
the movement of the feet is the maṇḍala by its very nature.
To abide in this way is the commitment.

Moreover, even the specific commitments —
in order to abandon worldly conventional speech,
the practices of Akṣobhya, Vairocana, and the rest,
and of the heroes and the ḍākinīs,
the secret vajra and lotus,
and indeed all conduct of playful engagement —
even conventional speech enters the path.

Furthermore, the secret commitments are:
four root and ten branch.

To disparage the Great Vehicle,
to denigrate the secret meaning,
to cause harm to any yogin,
and to injure any sentient being —
these are the secret commitments.

Also, the order of protecting what is hidden:
the commitment of taking what is not given.
Engaging in conduct of desire with great passion
is likewise similar to that.

In order to protect one's own commitment,
to speak falsehood is the fourth.

The flesh of a corpse and the flesh of vitality,
fermented drink made from sesame and sweet fermented drink —
butter is one, milk is two,
and another three make the ten branches.
Thus these are declared to be the commitments.

With respect to the nectar itself, at the three times,
pertaining to the body, speech, and mind of the Blessed One:
at the beginning, white mustard seed, and at the end,
eat in the manner of a cat's morsel.
At night: body, speech, and mind of wisdom.
By day: body, speech, and mind of skillful means.
Sunset, sunrise,
and midday are the times of skillful means.
Evening, dawn,
and the middle of the night are the times of wisdom.
The offering of the six periods is never to be interrupted.

If one falls into decline from this commitment,
the heroes and dākinīs dwelling in the world-realms of the ten directions
will offer worship, protection, and so forth.

Furthermore, regarding the particularities of the secret:
the yogin who cultivates the secret —
fire and blood shall not fall upon his body,
except for the purpose of life or intense pain.
If one sees a sentient being pursuing desire,
one must not let one's own yoga slip away.
Remain in seclusion to protect the commitment;
if one is capable of the task, then wander freely.

These, thus spoken, are the eight branches.
My fourteen are declared complete.

At the single time of hearing, the meaning of the fifty:
the Blessed One sets forth the four roots;
the Tathāgata, the ten branches.
Body, speech, and mind — body, speech, and mind —
because the vajra is inseparable, these are the commitments.

The queen, adorned and beautiful with commitments,
by the placing of the bhaga in equipoise —

equipoise unchanging across the three times —
abides in the essential nature of bliss.
Vajrasattva (vajrahṛdaya) and the rest
I have declared to be the particulars.

E: this is the eight branches.
BHĀ: this is the nature of the ten.
MA: this is the nature of the fifty.
YĀ: these, I declare, are the others.

E: the killing of living beings.
BHĀ: the taking of what is not given.
MA: speaking falsehood.
YĀ: engaging in desire.

E: the commitment of body.
BHĀ: the commitment of speech.
MA: the commitment of mind.
YĀ: the commitment of what is eaten.

If the commitment of the three times is not protected,
I declare that the karmic maturation
of becoming a worldling a hundred thousandfold will be great.

The signs of a degenerated commitment:
various faults of body arise,
various faults of speech are spoken,
complexion and form change,
the substances of the hand become powerless,
and abscesses, swellings, and the like appear.
At that time, that yogin of fallen state
should reflect deeply that his commitment has degenerated.

He shall assemble the guru and the vajra-siblings as a circle,
create a feast maṇḍala,
and offer a hundred or a thousand gold and silver and so forth,
horses, elephants, and the like,
lapis lazuli and crystal,
a hundred or a thousand parasols and victory banners,
lamps and the like — likewise all of these.

Turn the great wheel of the feast gathering,
and through the accumulation of the feast, restore what has degenerated.
If the degeneration is not restored,
one must not dwell even for a single moment
in the same place or the same water,
the same locality or road,
as that degenerate one and other yogins.
If one does dwell there, the faults are inconceivable.

Consecration ceremonies, fire offerings, empowerments,
torma offerings, recitations,
medicinal pills, eye medicines, and the like,
pacifying and enriching rites and the like,
the eight worldly signs,
the four supramundane signs,
the one sign of buddhahood —
and furthermore, without exception, all attainments (siddhis)
arise from this sacred commitment.

Just as grains of various kinds spring forth,
like jewels born from the earth,
the sacred commitment is the body, speech, and mind of the noble one,
and whoever transgresses it will be burned.
Just as a house without a son
falls empty the moment the owner dies,
likewise, without this sacred commitment,
one is born in the Avīci hell.

A lute, a flute — any stringed or wind instrument —
if separated from its resonance, cannot be sounded.
Likewise, without the sacred commitment,
recitation of mantra, meditation, and the like
will be squandered and bear no fruit.

From barley, a barley sprout grows.
Likewise, from the sacred commitment, Vajradhāra
is said to be attained in this very life.
The time is none other than this: the age of strife.
The teaching is none other than this: mine.
The birth is none other: the father and the mother.

The instruction is none other: the samaya.
These four, it is declared, are the case.

Thus, one who holds the sacred commitment
will find women gathering about him with delight.
The ḍākinīs, the yoginīs,
reveal the signs of body, speech, and mind.
Wealth, servants, retinues,
the domain of kings and so forth will assemble.
Speech becomes pleasant and easeful.
Even if words of killing and the like are spoken,
sentient beings will not be frightened.
Even if the body has killed sentient beings,
no karmic ripening will arise.
Attainment of the body is declared.
Even if speech utters words of slander,
no fault arises — the attainment of speech will come.
Even if the mind conceives thoughts of vengeance,
no fault arises — the attainment of mind will come.
Such are the qualities of one who holds the sacred commitment.

Ema ho! How wondrous is this tantra!

The King of Tantras, the Tantra of the Great Glorious Sacred Commitment, is complete.

The Indian abbot Gayādhara —

Translator's Notes

- The colophon at the opening names the Indian paṇḍita as Ratnavajra and the Tibetan translator as the monk Śākya Yeshe, with a note that the text was later revised against a fresh manuscript. This is a standard double colophon structure in the Kangyur tradition.

The phrase rendered "abiding in meditative absorption within the bhaga of the noble vajra-queen" follows the technical tantric formula in which the Buddha is described as dwelling in the sexual union of the consort; "bhaga" is a Sanskrit term left untranslated in the Tibetan as a loanword and is retained here as a recognized technical term in tantric literature.

The passage "from within the innumerable yoginīs, the great bodhisattva Vajragarbha smiled upon the bodhisattva Vajragarbha" is grammatically awkward in the source and may reflect an ellipsis or a distinction between an outer assembly figure and a questioner figure of the same name; this is a recognized textual feature in tantric sūtra-format openings.

The "fifty aspects" of the teacher refers to a standard enumeration of guru samaya obligations in Vajrayāna traditions. The "eight common" and "fourteen" commitments refer to the eight common samaya and the fourteen root tantric downfalls, well-attested in the tradition.

- The list of "four roots and ten branches" of the secret commitments corresponds to a standard tantric schema, but the Tibetan here is terse and the specific enumeration in this passage does not map precisely to all canonical lists. The rendering reflects the structure as given in the text.

The term rendered "flesh of vitality" for 肉之精華 is literally "flesh of essence" — this likely refers to a ritual substance; some commentaries gloss it as marrow or a particular flesh offering. The exact identification is uncertain.

"Vajrasattva and the rest" for ར་རྒྱལ་སྤྲོད་པའི་བཅས་ཀྱི་གཞི་མཛུགས།: the Tibetan reads rdorje snying po, literally "vajra-heart" or "vajra-essence," which could be an epithet of Vajrasattva or a distinct referent. It has been rendered as Vairasattva with a parenthetical clarification in the body.

The syllable-by-syllable analysis of E, BHĀ, MA, YĀ near the end of the passage appears to be a mnemonic or cryptic commentary breaking down the syllable EBHĀMAYĀ into four components, each assigned a category of root downfall, precept, and commitment. The passage is treated as structured verse accordingly.

- The passage closes with a colophon naming the translator team; the text breaks off after the Indian paṇḍita Gayādhara's name, suggesting the Tibetan translator's name followed in the manuscript but is not present in this excerpt.

The three verses declaring that killing, slander, and malicious thought bring no fault or bad ripening for one who holds the samaya are standard antinomian rhetoric found in certain Vajrayāna tantras. They are understood within the tradition as referring to the realized adept's non-dual state, not as ethical permissions for ordinary practitioners, and commentators consistently qualify them accordingly.

The "eight worldly signs" and "four supramundane signs" are technical categories of siddhi-indicators specific to this tantra's system; their precise enumeration would require the root commentary and is not determinable from this passage alone.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.